

1976

INDIA AT 60

THE UPPER HAND

<< REWIND

Indira Gandhi decided to play big sister. The Monopolies and Restrictive Trade Practices Act, passed in 1969, came into effect. The BBC was asked to close down operations in India for broadcasting a French film, *L'Inde Fantome*, by Louis Malle, which sought to depict the "real India". A nationwide land-grab movement by the CPI, Praja Socialist Party and Sanghata Socialist Party fizzled out with the arrest of 4,500 people. The same year, communist leader Jyoti Basu escaped an attempt on his life in Patna. The federal structure wobbled, with Tamil Nadu demanding devolution of power. In calling for early general elections and appealing to the electorate with a new socialist agenda and that famous campaign line, "They say *Indira hatao*, I say *garibi hatao*", she set in motion a new era of populism in Indian politics.



ROMANCING A NEW STAR

Shakti Samanta's *Kati Patang* became a hit at the box office not only for its tear-jerker storyline, but also for its music, which established Kishore Kumar as the voice of Rajesh Khanna. The film featured hit songs like *Na koi umang hai* and *Yeh jo mohabbat hai*. Asha Parekh's performance as a runaway bride pretending to be a widow was riveting. Khanna's star was on the ascendant.



FIRST CUT

- Fourteen-year-old Ved Prakash won the first gold for India in the light flyweight wrestling competition at the Commonwealth Games.
- Nagendra Singh became the first

Indian president of the International Court of Justice.

- The foundation stone of India's first and the world's largest coal-based fertiliser plant was laid at Talcher, Orissa.

<< DID YOU KNOW

The controversial 2,244-metre-long Farakka Barrage of West Bengal, built for the sharing of the Ganga waters, was completed in 1970, but the water was diverted only in 1975.